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Drifting by friction: Playing with ontologies of design

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Abstract: In this paper, I will trace the 'drift' that has happened in my PhD project, 'Designing for Playful Democratic Frictions'. I argue that it has been driven primarily by the *friction* that emerged between the diverse components in my 'research-assemblage'. The aim is not to resolve the friction, but rather to enhance and follow it as far as I can. I suggest that a playful attitude is helpful for lingering with this friction, and that such a stance can allow us to see things otherwise obscured by tales of historical necessity. This notion of *drifting by friction* may inspire strategies for design research that allow us to question the ontologies of design, potentially generating small openings for different conceptions of design to emerge.

Keywords: play design; drifting; friction; ontology

1. Introducing friction

This paper is sparked by a sensation that we, as design researchers, are too often settling for answers and solutions that are a little too neat and tidy, leaving important questions unexamined because they would also reveal our own doubts, insecurities, and vulnerabilities. As the call for this conference states, design has typically been seen as a 'a practice of smoothing away the rough edges of the world', and I want to propose that we can 'de-smooth' design, potentially turning it into a mode of resistance. What happens when a design research project consistently augments friction rather than reduce and resolve it, leading to both processes and outcomes that are ambiguous, inconsistent, and confusing?

Following the play design track, I explore how we as design researchers may be transformed by our encounters in the worlds we inhabit and traverse. I believe that the change we are so eager to bring about risks being curtailed by an insufficient understanding of how such change may presuppose our own transformation.

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I will take my point of departure with those recent trends in design research that question the epistemological and ontological underpinnings of design (Barcham, 2022; Escobar, 2018; Fry & Nocek, 2020). Tony Fry and Adam Nocek have argued that 'design must un-design its own designing, but in so doing, it cannot make this a design project. In short: design must become unrecognisable to itself.' (Fry & Nocek, 2020, p. 10). Their proposition may seem like a proper Gordian knot, but it also generates a fruitful friction I could not ignore. While I will readily admit that I find this idea deeply bewildering, I argue that we must find ways of talking about things we don't quite know how to talk about yet. We cannot always wait until our language is coherent, and our rational arguments are fully formed.

Along the way, you may get a little lost in the paper. In fact, I hope you do, as I agree with Jack Halberstam that getting lost is sometimes the best way to explore contingency and how things could be different (Halberstam, 2011). I propose the paper as a performative experiment in evoking and sustaining friction. As such, I would deem it successful to the extent that the friction is not resolved by the end.

I suspect that this paper might speak to those designers and design researchers who ask critical questions of design, such as 'how might we design together, differently?' (Disalvo, 2022, p. 242). In contrast, if you are looking for answers, method cards, toolkits or other concrete how-to instructions, this paper may not be for you.

1.1 Understanding Friction

When I talk about friction, I understand it as 'the rubbing of one body against another'[1]. Kathleen Stewart can help us see how we might sense friction as a 'surging, a rubbing, a connection of some kind that has an impact () bodies literally affecting one another and generating intensities: human bodies, discursive bodies, bodies of thought, bodies of water.' (Stewart, 2007, p. 128). Stewart's words indicate that friction is an affective experience which goes beyond the tangible, as it also includes friction with existing ideas, expectations, and with ways of knowing and being. Similarly, Laurent Berlant has described 'the affective sense of the familiar friction of being in relation' as a kind of inconvenience that 'is evident in micro-incidents like a caught glance, a brush on the flesh, the tack of a sound or smell that hits you, an undertone, a semiconscious sense of bodies copresent on the sidewalk' (Berlant, 2022, p. 14). Finally, Anna Tsing emphasized how friction can help us see the contingent nature of what is otherwise taken for granted, and she suggests that in order to 're-open mystery in our times', friction can help us to 'emerge from under the shadow of inevitability' (Tsing, 2005, p. 269). These perspectives suggest to me that generating and following friction can potentially help us rupture narratives of epistemological and ontological necessity and inevitability.

[1] See https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/friction

2. Methods of friction

I will explore friction as it emerged through my PhD project, 'The Junk Playground as Agora: Designing for Playful Democratic Frictions[2]'. In that project, I have developed the research program 'the junk playground as agora' to explore democratic participation as affective, bodily, and playful inquiries into matters of common concern.

2.1 The PhD as a research assemblage

Inspired by new materialism (Bennett, 2010; Coole & Frost, 2010), I have adopted the concept of 'research-assemblage' (Fox & Alldred, 2015a, 2017, 2023), which I understand as all the many different 'bodies, things and abstractions that get caught up in social inquiry' (Fox & Alldred, 2015b). All these components rub up against each other, and the ensuing friction, the pushing and pulling, the shifts and ruptures, as well as the recurring feelings of apathy and paralysis, alongside the moments of joy and possibility, all these persistent, affective flows are what sparked this paper.

2.2 Constructive design research

I situate my work in the broader fields of 'practice-based design research' (Vaughan, 2017) and 'research-through-design' (Frayling, 1993), where I am inspired by 'constructive design research' (Koskinen et al., 2011). Koskinen et al defined this as 'design research in which construction () takes center place and becomes the key means in constructing knowledge' (Koskinen et al., 2011, p. 5). In my project, construction refers both to constructing the junk playground and the construction that takes place *in* the playgrounds by the hands of the people playing. Within this tradition, Peter Gall Krogh and Ilpo Koskinen have developed the concept of 'drifting' to describe 'those actions that take design away from its original brief or question and lead to a result that was not anticipated in the beginning' (Krogh & Koskinen, 2020, p. 6). With this paper, I have developed the related concept of 'drifting by friction' to explore what happens when the drift follows the frictions, not to resolve them, but to understand where they might take us and which imaginaries of design they might allow us to see and sense.

2.3 Autoethnography

This paper is written in the tradition of autoethnography, which I find to be particularly useful here because it encourages me to trace 'the emotional, sensory, and material effects of

[2] I wrote this paper because I was stuck, unable to properly deal with the friction that shaped my PhD project. This paper is thus written in conjunction with my PhD thesis, which I submitted on January 8th 2024. The two processes have influenced and shaped each other, where writing this paper first changed my thesis, and later, ideas from the thesis migrated back into this paper as I have responded to the reviews.

experience that escape observation or even conscious awareness.' (Adams et al., 2021, p. 4). Autoethnographers also seek to establish an 'active and reciprocal relationship with audiences () in order to compel reflection, action, and reaction' (Adams et al., 2021, p. 7), and I hope this approach can both generate friction and invite conversation.

3. Friction tales

In the following, I will trace how layers of friction has appeared in different guises throughout the project. While I may analytically be peeling off these layers, they cannot be understood apart from each other, and it is the *accumulation* of frictions that will come to matter most. I take inspiration from Charlotte Wegener and Ninna Meier, when they insisted that we, as academics, need to also share 'stories of the routes we did not plan, the messy things we did and the results of it all—which we may not fully understand.' (Wegener et al., 2018, p. 15). To emphasise how I have been haunted by doubt, and how each layer of friction made me realise how little I knew or could control, I end each story with questions for which I still have no adequate answer.

Writing with friction

I am not particularly drawn to academic writing in its more classical, neat, and tidy guises. Though I may be able to write in ways that seem to fit the bill, I almost always end up with what Peter Elbow called 'defensive writing' which means 'not risking complicated thoughts or language, not risking half-understood ideas, not risking language that has the resonance that comes from being close to the bone.' (Elbow, 1998, p. xix). In contrast, I am inspired by Anna Tsing, when she insisted on writing as a 'hair in flour' to cause a 'disturbance of everyday subservience and routine' and to 'look for weaknesses, confusions, and gaps in business as usual' (Tsing, 2005, pp. 206–207).

If writing is more like the unpredictable experimental inquiries in the playgrounds, then how do I adhere to established academic standards?

Friction with language

I initially took for granted that I would be 'recruiting' participants for my design experiments. However, that word itself produced an intense friction with me. While it does indeed mean something as innocuous as 'to enroll', it nonetheless seemed to betray the gentle sensitivity I hoped would underpin and guide the entire project. Recruitment sounded hard and technical, like a unidirectional process controlled by me, and I just couldn't shake the associations to the military – a recruit, recruiting an army. Instead, I was drawn to the word 'attunement' as a strategy for fostering engagement. That word affected me differently, it seemed much less controlled, and deterministic, softer, evoking a sense of mutual ownership. When

Megan Watkins wrote about affective attunement taking place between teacher and students, she suggested that in some cases, 'the excitement and interest that are generated prove contagious with other students keen to be involved as part of the experience' (Gregg & Seigworth, 2010, p. 283). This was exactly what I was dreaming about: making an *invitation* that people would be drawn to and intrigued by, like Kristina Lindström and Åsa Ståhl's invitations that address 'an area of curiosity' (Lindström & Ståhl, 2016).

Is it really viable to choose words based on their affective qualities and how they make me feel, rather than what they mean?

Friction with organizations

I crafted invitations to share on social media, which led to numerous responses from people curious about my project. One of the first meetings took place at a small museum. The three people I met with echoed each other in insisting that they 'work somewhat unconventionally' and their approach often generated a friction through what they described as a 'resistance towards or even fear of change'. Another meeting was at a library, where we quickly got into exploring connections between my proposal and both their professional and personal lives. One said that the boundaries around their work were often 'too narrow'. Another lamented that they were 'wrapped in the municipal', where there always needs to be 'progression and a plan'. In contrast, they talked about play as 'magic', as affording a special 'presence' where no external goals were required. 'I myself have this longing to play' one person revealed, while another said that they 'had really missed this (play) in her adult world', where 'things have to be in a certain manner'.

Across these meetings, people shared a sense of confinement, of bumping up against rigid structures and 'too narrow boundaries', as one person expressed it. It seems like my invitations sparked an interest by intensifying a friction these people had already experienced within their organisations and current practices.

If my proposition creates friction with the structures of their work-life, then how can it ever be feasible for them to join in?

Friction with materials

When we started conducting the junk playground experiments, each experiment was centred around a collection of discarded materials, consisting of everything from wooden pallets, boards and beams, iron rods, tubes and pipes, tarps, tires and wheels, fabrics, rope, to old electronics like microwaves and kettles.



Figure 1 - Junk playground materials

All participants were invited to explore the piles of materials, and I always emphasized that they should follow their hands and bodies. This caused considerable friction with many participants, most of whom were more familiar with what Amanda Machin has called 'the myth of disembodied rationality' (Machin, 2022, p. 14), the ideal of mind over matter. One person turned this into a mantra, writing 'down into the hands, out of the head' and 'out of the head, down into the hands' over and over:

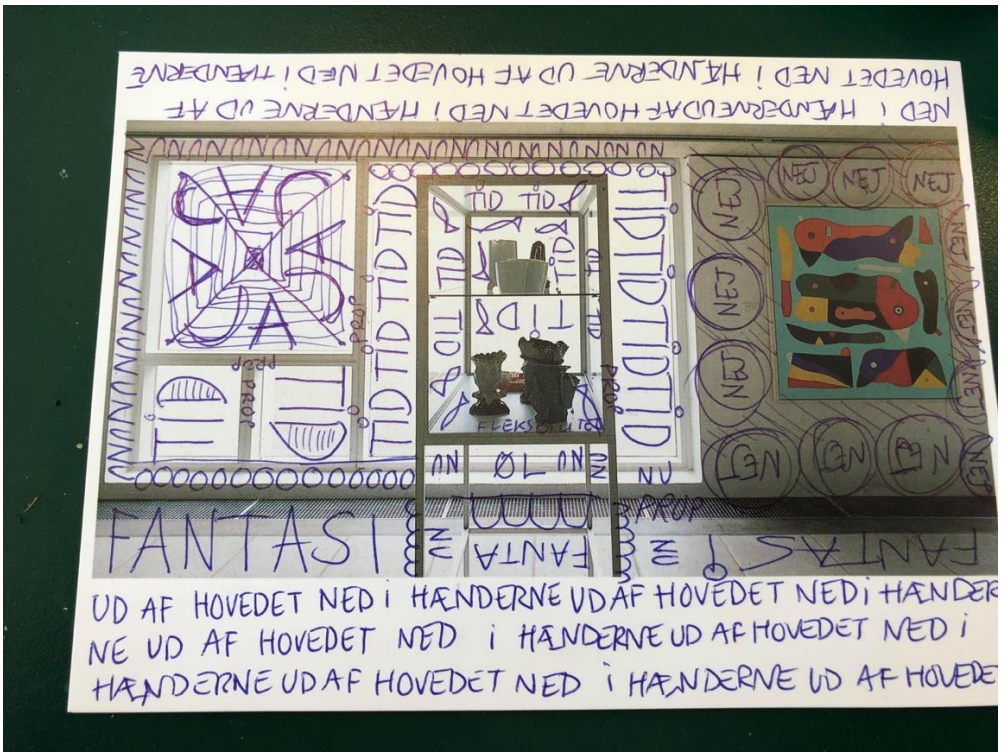


Figure 2 – Written reflections

And on the other side of the postcard they wrote:

'I have just been exposed to a situation – an assignment, which frustrated me a lot. I was challenged on my imagination, or perhaps rather my often very concrete way of thinking. It can be hard to move out of your head and into your hands. I will not claim that I succeeded. I fell in love with a big iron pipe/rod, which constrained my creative and imaginative journey into an unknown future'.

If the junk playgrounds ask people to move 'out of the head', then how do I reconcile that with ideals of rational discourse? What if these materials have greater agency than stories of human exceptionalism allow us to see?

Friction with purpose

Where the physical materials provided friction in abundance, friction also grew from the *purpose* of the experiments. Or rather, the *lack* of a clearly defined purpose. In one experiment, someone asked me to elaborate on the task:

'What are we supposed to do?'

I tried to help without providing definitive answers, and I merely invited them explore, through the materials, what their shared future might look like. A little later, I overheard a conversation that the group was having:

'But maybe the most important thing is not the result, or even that we have something finished to show, but rather the conversations we're having?'

They did not resolve the friction, they merely accepted to stay with it a little longer, and I suspect that they simply got carried away by the play experience.

If we are often judged by results and outcomes, then how do I account for this lack of a clearly defined purpose? What if the dominant concern with clear goals and outcomes overshadows more important matters?

Friction with design research

I made a conscious effort to linger with the frictions for as long as possible, to the point of madness, even when experienced design scholars told me that I couldn't, that I would have to 'close down', to make decisions, to *converge*. Why did I not heed the advice of all these sensible, well-meaning people? I don't know, exactly, it was intuition, an affective sensation that it would be a mistake, that the possible contributions of my work could only ever emerge from the sustained openness, from following the friction just a little bit longer.

In their different ways, many people have conveyed to me a 'design discourse where knowledge is rhetorically and persuasively presented in rational, impersonal, and publicly

contestable ways.' (Akama & Yee, 2016, p. 5). It reminds me that even those of us who acknowledge and embrace the messiness of design research typically share the belief that it must be dealt with, somehow, that mess must become order in the end, and that it's our primary job to make friction go away.

As the faintest of whispers, almost drowned out by modern ideals, I hear myself ask:

What if it's not?

4. Implications of friction

As the incessant frictions and the unanswered, if not unanswer*able*, questions piled up, I arrived at the edge of what I thought could be known. It was as if the reality I knew was no longer enough, rendering me unable to grasp all the mess and friction ensuing from this project. As Judith Butler argued:

'one does not drive to the limits for a thrill experience, or because limits are dangerous and sexy, or because it brings us into a titillating proximity with evil. One asks about the limits of ways of knowing because one has already run up against a crisis within the epistemological field in which one lives' (Butler, 2001, p. 3)

I kept bumping up against those 'limits of ways of knowing' and friction ensued. For Laurent Berlant, every relation to anyone or anything comes with a certain degree of inconvenience that generates a 'force that makes one shift a little while processing the world' (Berlant, 2022, p. 14). Though I was not aware what the frictions meant, they pushed and dragged me to become something I was not yet, that I needed to be, see, think, and write differently. Berlant also discussed the idea of 'transformational infrastructures' and the possibility of becoming otherwise. She suggested that the crucial thing is to 'loosen up at the moment when everything in me would prefer not to' (Berlant, 2022, p. 223). I was not immediately compelled to follow the frictions, and in many cases I would have preferred not to, but I tried to loosen up. Marisol de la Cadena used the notion of disconcertment to describe 'the feeling that assaults individuals—including their bodies—when the categories that pertain to their world-making practices and institutions are disrupted' (de la Cadena, 2015, p. 276). I believe this is what was happening: my familiar categories were being disrupted and I had to find a way to deal with that. Cadena also noted that 'not infrequently, disconcertment is explained away' (de la Cadena, 2015, p. 276). In the same manner, I could have made these frictions disappear, describing them as anomalies and outliers, or I could have simply abstained from mentioning them altogether.

Only, I could not. Not this time.

While it was not one specific incidence that compelled me to stay with the friction, there is no doubt that briefly leaving the comforting familiarity of Denmark behind was a decisive factor. During my PhD project, I spent three months in Australia, visiting the Emerging Technologies Lab at Monash in Melbourne, and the Centre for Deliberative Democracy and Global Governance at University of Canberra. I arrived with no elaborate plan, but my intuitive strategy was to be like a sponge, to soak up as much as I could of everything while I was there. I went to small and big galleries, to openings of exhibitions, to niche theatre performances, everything I could find. Across all these experiences, what affected and moved me the most were all those artists who created friction with persistent colonial narratives.

It was against this background, enmeshed in friction and far away from home, that I found myself at the University of Canberra, where Professor Nicole Curato was about to give her inaugural lecture, asking 'Can there be a global deliberative democracy?'. 'Shouldn't I be celebrating the mainstreaming of deliberative democracy around the world?' she asked and then immediately revealed that 'something doesn't feel quite right'. She turned the tables, questioning her own work and that of her colleagues. 'Is deliberation, rooted as it is in Habermasian ideals from Eurocentric enlightenment and western modernity, enough?' she asked rhetorically. 'We include indigenous people in citizen assemblies but doesn't this just tiptoe around the issue - that we are standing on stolen land?'

This was not new to me as such, but I was reacting affectively in a more profound manner than my cognitive capacities could comprehend. It was overwhelming and moving. The friction from this situation, alongside all the other frictions in the research assemblage, pushed me towards deep, transformative shifts, probably because it resonated with a growing suspicion that we, in the West, are long past the point where we should start listening to voices other than our own. At the beginning of my PhD, I imagined that I would stay within the world I knew, which was largely a Eurocentric world with its Enlightenment ideals of the autonomous, rational individual. There is no escaping my own position and I am painfully aware that 'old epistemological habits tend to reinsert themselves behind our own backs' (MacLure, 2017, p. 56). I remain steeped in the legacy of Western Modernity, but I hope that I am also slowly becoming something else, something a little more open to other ways of knowing and being.

5. Sensing friction

Whereas the arrival at this destination marks an important step on my personal journey, here it mainly serves as an illustration, *one* possible outcome of following the frictions. We are all different, and we will all drift in different ways. In fact, Krogh and Koskinen argued that 'drifting is a function of epistemological beliefs' (Krogh & Koskinen, 2022, p. 33). In other words, the way we drift in our research projects depend on our beliefs about what constitutes knowledge in the first place. However, I do not merely see drifting as a function of established 'epistemological beliefs', but also as a force with the potential to *change*

those beliefs *and* the ontological ground on which they rest. In their understanding of 'drifting by intention', drifting happens 'not as driftwood, but as in car rally; intentionally and controlled' (Krogh & Koskinen, 2020b, p. 44). At this point, I find it increasingly difficult to think of myself and my research as a rally car drifting intentionally and controlled. As I have tried to show with my friction tales, 'unpredictable encounters transform us; we are not in control, even of ourselves () we are thrown into shifting assemblages, which remake us' (Tsing, 2015, p. 20).

This takes me back to the argument from the beginning, that 'design must become unrecognizable to itself'. Fry and Nocek further argued that 'the challenge for design, insofar as it is part and parcel of the fabrication of the Anglo-Eurocentric subject of Reason, is to undermine its own ontological ground.' (Fry & Nocek, 2020, p. 3). I suggest that to achieve this, we could practice moving into the borderlands, a liminal space between different worlds rooted in different ontologies. Gloria Anzaldua argued that to 'explore the 'cracks between the worlds () we must see through the holes in reality' (Anzaldua, 2015, p. 44). Doing this, moving in the cracks between worlds, is a practice, something to learn, that brings with it 'a new way of viewing the world, and you bring this 'magical' knowledge and apply it to the everyday world' (Anzaldua, 2015, pp. 44–45). Walter Mignolo, drawing on Anzaldua, argued that 'the point is not to study the borders' while still dwelling comfortably in 'the imperial epistemology of modernity' (Mignolo in Reiter, 2018, p. xi). If we are merely lingering within familiar territory, we may be, as Maria Lugones argued 'at ease'. If we are *too* much at ease, too reliant on the world we know, there is an inherent risk that we 'have no inclination to travel across 'worlds'' (Lugones, 1987, p. 12), to visit each other's worlds and then mutual understanding is all but impossible. When these cracks and borders are often not tangible, they call for a kind of 'border sensing' that, according to Mignolo, is often affective, 'something that invades your emotions, and your body responds to it, dictating to the mind what the mind must start thinking, changing its direction, shifting the geography of reasoning.' (Reiter, 2018, p. xii). I sense a connection with what I consider arguably design's greatest strength, the bodily sensitivity towards the material dimension that grows from years of practice being in dialogue with materials. This generates a knowledge that resides in the body of the designer, and it can never be adequately captured, neither by language nor by even the best method cards or process models. I believe this affective sensitivity would be particularly helpful in traversing the borderlands. Here, we must, as Donna Haraway has famously argued, reject the 'god tricks' promising vision from 'everywhere and nowhere' (Haraway, 1988, p. 584). There is no safe distance from which to observe these things, these are affective matters as much as intellectual ones, and only in the thick of it will the cracks appear. This has implications for anyone who hopes to move into the cracks and obtain even a gaze of other worlds, because we must become different, too. How could we see what we could not see if we did not change enough to see differently?

While there are many possible ways of engaging with this critical predicament, I contend that play, because of its inherently affective nature, allows us to experience alterity in the

flesh, an enactment or prefiguration of being and becoming different. In my work, I have followed a familiar, simple idea from play theory, suggesting that when we play, we seek to spark and maintain an oscillating motion between order and disorder, between finding and losing our balance (Henricks, 2015, loc. 4139). This mirrors the playful attitude described by Miguel Sicart, when he argues that to be playful means 'taking over a world to see it through the lens of play, to make it shake and laugh and crack because we play with it.' (Sicart, 2014, p. 24).

Frictioning friction

This paper has been an experiment in following and evoking friction as an affective experience, and I hope it shows how I have been affected and transformed. However, friction is no panacea, and while it may help us create cracks and openings in established ontologies, it offers no immediate solutions. Furthermore, it is inherently difficult to commandeer and steer the friction in certain directions. In many contexts, the very idea of enhancing friction will be undesirable, because it flies in the face of efficiency, productivity, and the speed with which everything is expected to operate. While that is exactly my point, I am aware that it will not always be a welcome or meaningful proposition.

6. Perpetuating friction

In the spirit of this paper, I do not end with any unambiguous conclusions. Instead, I aim to sustain the dilemmas and extend the friction into the future.

At many points on this journey, I felt like I had simply failed. Failed to make sense of things, to create some semblance of order, to be a proper researcher. However, I have come to believe that failure is simply 'an inherent and necessary part of inquiry practices, creating critical junctures where we might pause, reflect, and possibly think otherwise' (Lammes et al., 2023, p. 50). My incessant failures to explain things with the theory I knew has indeed provided me with a series of 'critical junctures' where I have felt the opportunity to pause, reflect and think otherwise.

In the introduction to this paper, I suggested that 'drifting by friction' could be understood as a 'mode of resistance'. While I have traced and discussed *frictions*, I argue that I have also been uncovering facets of resistance, if mostly in an implicit manner. More explicitly, I suggest that drifting by friction may inspire and encourage a resistance towards familiar ways of thinking, acting and being, as the frictions are shaking and destabilizing our epistemological and ontological assumptions and beliefs. In the field of design research, I consider it a mode of resistance towards design as 'a practice of smoothing away the rough edges of the world', resisting solutionism and the belief that even problems arising from design itself are merely 'opportunities waiting to be fixed by a new design' (Busch & Palmås, 2023, p. 17). Drifting by friction also points to a broader resistance that engages with the contemporary conditions of

academic life in the wake of the 'global audit culture' (Spooner, 2017) where we are 'increasingly governed by and through numbers, incentives, de-incentives and competitive benchmarking' (McNinch & Spooner, 2018, p. xxiv). Drifting by friction may carve out small pockets for critically examining and resisting such dominant logics by exploring an *academia otherwise*.

Under these conditions, I cannot merely understand drifting by friction as a resistance turned outward and elsewhere. The resistance I speak of is thus also very much a continuous effort to resist myself when I am regularly tempted to comply with the expectations of smooth efficiency and productivity. As Berlant noted, in any aspiration to transformation we are faced with the daunting challenge of loosening up 'at the moment when everything in me would prefer not to' (Berlant, 2022, p. 223). Drifting by friction means turning towards the friction, not away from it, enhancing it rather than resolving or ignoring it altogether. Drifting by friction means accepting the invitation to be shaken by the ruptures, to be loosened and transformed, to become otherwise and potentially unrecognisable to oneself. Not all at once, not in one powerful stroke, but over time, step by step, it builds up like an accumulation of affective impulses and forces. We are reminded that we can design for friction, and that such friction can be sustained for longer than is typically assumed or preferred. If we stay with the friction, new perspectives and imaginaries can emerge from that tension. Those opportunities are fruitfully enabled by play because play thrives on friction and the constant shifts and movements.

What now? What to *make* of all this? Where does a paper end?

Like Anna Tsing asked, 'what kind of book is this that refuses to end?' (Tsing, 2015, p. 287). Is this a situation where 'stories should never end, but rather lead to further stories'? Yes, I believe it is. The design research I try to call forth here is work that, first and foremost, generates frictions and cultivates a stance of resistance, repeatedly and in perpetuity.

If this seems like an insurmountable task, then we may do well to remember that friction also offers a connective tissue, where we can better endure and possibly even enjoy the friction together. Perhaps friction can even inspire hope in these difficult times. Not because it allows us to solve our problems more efficiently, but because it rejects such simple solutionism. The hope I talk about here is that which 'locates itself in the premises that we don't know what will happen and that in the spaciousness of uncertainty is room to act' (Solnit, 2016, p. xiv). Play embodies hope exactly because it lives in and of uncertainty and friction, insisting that there is always some room to act. In other words: as long as there is friction, there is hope.

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